Themes

1. Giving in to temptation can cost you what matters most.
2. Appearances can deceive: what looks lovely and welcoming can hide danger.
3. Caution can protect you, while trusting too easily can lead you into a trap.
4. Comfort and pleasure can make you forget your goals.

from

The Odyssey

An Epic Poem by **Homer**

Translated by **Robert Fitzgerald**

Part Two: from Books 10–12

"*The* lovely voices in ardor appealing over the water made me crave to listen, and I tried to say 'Untie me!' to the crew, jerking my brows."

The Enchantress Circe (from Book 10)

After escaping the Cyclopes' island, Odysseus and his men land on the island of Aeolus (ē′ ə ləs), king of the winds. Aeolus assists him by putting all of the unfavorable winds in a bag, which he gives to Odysseus. His curious crew, however, rip open the bag, and

the hurricane-like winds blow the ships far off course. In the days that follow, Odysseus and his men fight a battle with cannibals on Laestrygonia (les trig ō′ nē ə), in which they lose many men and all but one of their ships. Odysseus and his remaining men then arrive on the island of the goddess and sorceress Circe (sʉr′ sē). Though his men are fearful of what they may find there, Odysseus sends out a scouting party.

"In the wild wood they found an open glade
around a smooth stone house—the hall of Circe—
and wolves and mountain lions lay there, mild
in her soft spell, fed on her drug of evil.
None would attack—oh, it was strange, I tell you—
but switching their long tails they faced our men
like hounds, who look up when their master comes
with tidbits for them—as he will—from table.
Humbly those wolves and lions with mighty paws
fawned on our men—who met their yellow eyes
and feared them.
In the entrance way they stayed
to listen there: inside her quiet house
they heard the goddess Circe.
Low she sang
in her beguiling voice, while on her loom
she wove ambrosial fabric sheer and bright,
by that craft known to the goddesses of heaven.
No one would speak, until Polites—most
faithful and likable of my officers, said:

'Dear friends, no need for stealth: here's a young weaver
singing a pretty song to set the air
a-tingle on these lawns and paven courts.
Goddess she is, or lady. Shall we greet her?'

So reassured, they all cried out together,
and she came swiftly to the shining doors
to call them in. All but Eurylochus—
who feared a snare—the innocents went after her.
On thrones she seated them, and lounging chairs,
while she prepared a meal of cheese and barley
and amber honey mixed with Pramnian wine,
adding her own vile pinch, to make them lose
desire or thought of our dear father land.
Scarce had they drunk when she flew after them
with her long stick and shut them in a pigsty—

be • guil • ing (bi gī′ liŋ) *adj.*, outwardly charming but inwardly deceptive
stealth (stelth) *n.*, sneakiness; secretiveness

bodies, voices, heads, and bristles, all
swinish now, though minds were still unchanged.
So, squealing, in they went. And Circe tossed them
acorns, mast, and cornel berries—fodder
for hogs who rut and slumber on the earth.
Down to the ship Eurylochus came running
to cry alarm, foul magic doomed his men![1]
But working with dry lips to speak a word
he could not, being so shaken; blinding tears
welled in his eyes; foreboding filled his heart.
When we were frantic questioning him, at last
we heard the tale: our friends were gone. . . ."

Odysseus leaves the ship at once to confront Circe himself. Protected from her spells with help from Hermes, Odysseus convinces the goddess to restore his shipmates to their human form. Odysseus and his crew dally on Circe's island for a year. When Odysseus decides they must head home, Circe tells him he will not return safely unless he goes to the Land of the Dead to seek advice from the blind seer Teiresias.

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1. **magic doomed his men.** Crew members enslaved by Circe's tricks